about half the FRG’s. Measured against the former performance of this part of Germany, this is a situation for which the communist party leadership must take the responsibility.

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The bottom line: Honecker’s seemingly healthy economy was built on sand.

As often happened after shaky periods in GDR-FRG relations, the climate suddenly improved. In September, Honecker greeted West Berlin’s Mayor, Richard von Weizsäcker, and signalled his willingness to relax money exchange rules for visiting Westerners. During his trip, the mayor met the SED cabinet, including Egon Krenz, whose star was steadily rising. By this point, he had become the youngest member of the Politburo and taken on the role of secretary of the central committee with responsibility for security; the same position Honecker had held until 1971. Within the coming year, Krenz gained supreme prominence when appointed Honecker’s deputy on the Council of State, thus making him the second-most powerful man in the country.